



ABUSED BY THE BADGE



CAROLYN VAN HOUTEN/THE WASHINGTON POST

Former Maypearl, Texas, police chief Kevin Coffey during a prison interview.

THE ‘PERFECT’ PREDATOR

How a police chief with a troubled past groomed a small Texas town

This article is by Jenn Abelson, Alice Li, Jessica Contrera, Tucker Harris and Carolyn Van Houten

MAYPEARL, TEXAS — The new police chief quickly impressed the small Texas community he'd sworn to protect. He started a Christmas charity event. He checked on elderly neighbors. He seemed especially good, residents noted, with troubled teenagers. The people of Maypearl trusted Police Chief Kevin Coffey. Few were aware that Maypearl was the eighth law enforcement agency that Coffey had worked



COURTESY OF THE WAXAHACHIE DAILY LIGHT

Coffey during his time as police chief.

at in 11 years. Fewer knew that there was a trail of accusations and secrets in his past. And none could have predicted the destruction he would wreak in their town. The kids would eventually call him The Creeper. The adults would denounce him as a monster. The prosecutors who put him away for child sexual abuse would describe him as a master manipulator “who groomed the community.” But Coffey, sitting behind a glass partition in a state prison, would struggle to describe himself — and how he got away with exploiting his power for so long.

SEE MAYPEARL ON A10

GOP scraps deal on budget after revolt from right

WITHOUT ACTION, SHUTDOWN IS DAYS AWAY

Pressure from Musk, Trump dooms bipartisan bill

BY MARIANNA SOTOMAYOR AND JACOB BOGAGE

Republicans scrapped House Speaker Mike Johnson's bipartisan plan to avert a government shutdown, as President-elect Donald Trump and Elon Musk joined a broad swath of the House GOP on Wednesday to condemn a compromise bill full of Democratic policy priorities. The rebuke, which built steadily through the day and culminated with a long written statement

from Trump in the late afternoon, has forced Johnson back to the drawing board on a plan to prevent a Christmastime shutdown — and maintain the support of his chaotic conference to be reelected as speaker early next year. “Your elected representatives have heard you and now the terrible bill is dead,” Musk boasted on X, the social media site he owns, after he spent the day blasting the measure. “The voice of the people has triumphed!”

SEE HOUSE ON A4

@PKCapitol: Speaker's critics and allies alike are frustrated. A2

Pentagon policy: Senate passes bill with controversial addition. A4

Musk: On X, the “DOGE” leader went on an hours-long tirade. A6

Local implications: Key Bridge funds, RFK deal face unraveling. B1

Fed lowers rates again, points to inflation ahead

Stocks plunge as central bank signals two cuts in 2025, down from four

BY ANDREW ACKERMAN

The Federal Reserve lowered interest rates on Wednesday by an additional quarter percentage point while pulling back on planned rate cuts next year as inflation proves to be a bigger challenge than its earlier estimates. The Fed penciled in just two rate cuts for 2025, down from

four forecast in September, emphasizing that future cuts would depend on progress toward curbing inflation and continued strength in the labor market. Stocks plunged following the rate cut, as investors soured on the news that interest rates would remain higher for longer than expected in 2025. The Dow Jones Industrial Average declined more than 1,100 points, or 2.6 percent, extending its longest losing streak in five decades. Inflation has weighed heavily on Americans, especially those with middle and lower incomes, and it drove voters to the polls in November to elect Donald

SEE RATES ON A20

Analysis of ancient DNA hints at syphilis's origin

Study suggests disease emerged in the Americas before ravaging Europe

BY CAROLYN Y. JOHNSON

In 1495, a devastating infection began to sweep across Europe, causing pustules and sores to erupt on people's bodies and faces. Accusatory finger-pointing about the scourge, syphilis, began almost immediately. The Italians called it “the French disease”; the French called it “the Neapolitan disease”; the Russians called it “the Polish disease.” The sexually transmitted disease remains a public health menace today, despite the fact that it is easily cured with antibiotics. But the scientific debate still rages about the ancient origins of syphilis — including why the wave of illness that swamped Renaissance Europe was so virulent. Did syphilis initially emerge in the Americas and arrive in Europe in early 1493 when explorer Christopher Columbus returned to Spain, in the reverse of so many other illnesses that wiped out Indigenous peoples? Or was it a much older “pre-Columbian” disease that has been infecting humanity much longer — one that

flew under the radar, perhaps mistaken for leprosy or another ailment in Medieval Europe? In a study published Wednesday in the journal Nature, an international team studied ancient DNA harvested from lesion-ridden bones or teeth of five people who lived in Peru, Chile, Argentina and Mexico either before or around the time of Columbus. They found that early versions of the microbe, *Treponema pallidum*, that causes syphilis and related diseases were already diverse and widespread. Their analysis suggests that syphilis emerged in the Americas within the last 8,000 years and spread across the globe fueled by European colonization. “The syphilis debate was a big one, and it was a very emotional one ... a famous paleopathologist described it as one of the most enigmatic questions in science,” said Kirsten Bos, group leader for molecular paleopathology at the Max Planck Institute for Evolutionary Anthropology and one of the leaders of the work. She argued the new evidence would settle the matter. “It's a very clear slam dunk: Okay, this clearly came from the Americas.” Several outside researchers agreed the study provides valuable new evidence strongly suggesting an American origin for

SEE SYPHILIS ON A8



LORENZO TUGNOLI FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Sheikh Ahmed Banawi and his family stop at a checkpoint Monday on the way out of al-Hakeem in Syria's Latakia province. The Alawite family was leaving the village out of fear of reprisals.

Revenge attacks in Syria fuel fear, mistrust

Vigilantes exploit post-Assad chaos to settle personal and sectarian scores

This article is by Loveday Morris, Suzan Haidamous, Louisa Loveluck, Nilo Tabrizy and Imogen Piper

AL-HAKEEM, SYRIA — The woman was clutching her infant, still in the dressing gown and pajamas she had been wearing a day earlier when fighters

overran this village in Syria's Latakia province, the heartland of Bashar al-Assad's Alawite minority sect. Her scorched home still radiated heat from the fires they had set. She hadn't seen her husband since he fled into the citrus groves. “We are dying from fear,” she

said, standing outside the house, speaking on the condition of anonymity for fear of reprisals. “It's as though our hearts are in our hands.” Rebels burned four homes Sunday in the retaliatory attack, a day after a family in al-Hakeem had attacked one of

SEE SYRIA ON A17

Justices to consider challenge to TikTok ban

BY ANN E. MARIMOW AND EVA DOU

The Supreme Court said Wednesday that it will quickly take up TikTok's challenge to a federal law that would shutter the popular platform next month unless the company divests from Chinese ownership. The justices said they would consider whether the law, passed with bipartisan support to address national security concerns, violates the First Amendment rights of millions of TikTok users and the owners of the video-sharing platform. In a sign of the significance of the issue, the court added a special hearing to its calendar, scheduling two hours for oral argument Jan. 10. A ruling could come any time after that. TikTok had asked the high court to intervene before Jan. 19, the deadline Congress set for TikTok's China-based parent company, ByteDance, to sell the platform or be barred in the United States. The company wants the justices to put on hold a lower-court ruling that clears the way for the law, which was signed by President Joe Biden.

SEE COURT ON A6

IN THE NEWS

Special counsel The Justice Department is reviewing whether Jack Smith and his team ran afoul of any regulations in its federal prosecutions of Donald Trump. A8

Chinese military Beijing's buildup has been hampered by an anti-corruption purge but still continues rapidly, the Pentagon found. A9

THE NATION A patient in Louisiana has the first severe illness caused by bird flu in the United States. A3

The House Ethics Committee is set to release a report on Matt Gaetz this week. A6

THE WORLD Denmark freed an anti-whaling activist, rejecting calls by Japan for him to be extradited. A14

Across the West, the liberal establishment has fallen out of favor, writes Ishaan Tharoor. A15

THE ECONOMY A California man's family filed a wrongful-death lawsuit against Amazon One Medical, alleging it was “reckless and negligent.” A19

Some credit card companies may be breaking the law by illegally devaluing rewards, a federal watchdog said. A20

THE REGION Virginia Gov. Glenn Youngkin preached bipartisanship and echoed Trump while laying out his budget plan, which includes \$50 million in school vouchers. B1

Tired of rowdy behavior, a D.C. cafe is trying to ban patrons under 30 after 8:30 p.m. B1

STYLE Joshua Oppenheimer reveals what drove him to infuse a postapocalyptic tale with song and dance in “The End.” C1

LOCAL LIVING Hollywood professionals explain the design magic behind the homes in two beloved holiday films.

BUSINESS NEWS.....	A19
COMICS.....	C5
OBITUARIES.....	B4
OPINION PAGES.....	A21
TELEVISION.....	C4
WORLD NEWS.....	A14

CONTENT © 2024
The Washington Post
Year 148, No. 54070

